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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

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Research Topic: Cognitive Behavior

Title: The correlation between children's ability to communicate and their consumption of "brainrot" content online, and parental mediation

Research Problem

"Brainrot" is a term used to refer to the supposed deterioration of a person's mental or intellectual state which results from the overconsumption of insignificant or unchallenging digital content [9]. Although extensive research has been conducted to study the relationship between screen time and children's language development, research on "brainrot" as a separate and specific content type is little to none [1], [6]. This study will have a mixed-methods design, combining questionnaires and semi-structured interviews to examine the brainrot content consumption patterns of children aged 8-12, their communication abilities, both linguistic and pragmatic skills, and how parental involvement can affect children's communication abilities.

Existing Literature

"Brainrot" was chosen as Oxford Word of the Year in 2024 due to the usage of the term surging by approximately 230% between 2023 and 2024 which reflects the global concern about short-form video and meaningless content consumption [9]. In academic literature, "Brainrot behavior" has been defined as a behavioral pattern associated with problematic social media use. Research indicates that experiential avoidance and subjective well-being serve as sequential mediation between parental marital conflict and adolescent brainrot behavior, suggesting brainrot consumption to be closely linked to emotional regulation and psychological adjustments and not a habitual issue [3].

In terms of content, brainrot videos typically include no narrative structure, high-saturation visual stimulation, repetitive simple soundtracks, and illogical spliced animations [10]. Italian brainrot is an example of this type of content, surreal visual imagery generated by AI with narratives that does not make sense which quickly gained popularity.

A systematic review shows that interactive and educational screen content may positively influence language development and executive functions, assuming that screen time is within the recommended limits, whereas excessive passive screen time shows negative impacts on cognitive and social skills, affecting attention, memory, and emotional regulation [6]. In terms of pragmatic communication, it was found that excessive screen exposure affects attention to environmental stimuli, social experiences, problem-solving, and communication abilities, indicating that screen exposure also affects the social use of language [5]. Although research on short-form video platforms has begun to examine its effects and influences on communication skills, oral communication, and written communication, it is yet to focus on brainrot content specifically [7].

Parental mediation is a key variable in the correlation between screen use and child developmental outcomes. Digital parenting research categorizes parental mediation into three main strategies: restrictive mediation, active mediation, and co-use mediation [2], [8]. In the correlation between scree use and language development, high-quality parent-

child interaction and verbal communication during screen time can lower harmful effects [5], [6].

However, there are still research gaps. First, there is a lack of research done on brain-rot content and children's communication abilities. Second, the effectiveness of parental involvement in the context of brainrot content is yet to be tested. Third, the pragmatic aspects of communication ability have been neglected.

Research Question

This study aims to answer the following questions:

1. What is the correlation between children's brainrot content consumption and their communication abilities?
2. How does the frequency, duration, content type of children's brainrot content consumption affect their linguistic and pragmatic skills?
3. Does parental involvement have effects on the relationship between brainrot content consumption and children's communication abilities? If yes, to what extent?
4. Are there differences in brainrot content consumption patterns and communication abilities across different age groups?

Methodology

As brainrot is an emerging phenomenon, this study adopts a mixed-methods design where quantitative data can reveal general patterns, and qualitative data can capture details of individual experience [4].

Quantitative Component: A basic language and pragmatic abilities test, naming objects, following orders, participation of group activity in the form of a play date, conducting Children's Communication Checklist-2, will be carried out to identify the cognitive behavior of children from a sample size of 400 children, aged 8-12, and 400 parents, selected using stratified random sampling. Descriptive statistics and correlation analysis will examine zero-order correlations between brainrot content consumption and communication ability. Hierarchical regression analysis will test the moderating effect of parental mediation in different degrees such as restricting screen time to some hours to not allowing children to use screens.

Qualitative Component: From the quantitative sample, 20 parents and 20 children will be selected for semi-structured interviews. The selection criteria will be based on high versus low frequency of brainrot content consumption. Children will be asked about the type of content, the frequency, and the duration of consumption. Parents will also be asked about the type of content their children consume, and the estimated frequency and duration of the consumption. When identifying brainrot content, children's screen time on short-form video platforms such as TikTok and YouTube. Specifically for YouTube, YouTube shorts and videos containing AI-generated videos of exaggerated movements and dialogues with no sense of direction or story will be taken into account. Additionally,

parents will be questioned about their forms of mediation. For qualitative analysis, the six steps of reflexive thematic analysis will be used: familiarization with data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and producing the report [4].

Research Topic

With different levels of AI-generated content, AI-generated short dramas and AI-generated cartoons, there should be rising concern on how these types of content affect the next generation. Before brainrot became a phenomenon, children left with electronic devices often resort to child friendly games or child friendly content such as Cocomelon. However, with the increase in short-form video content, even adults are facing issues related to attention span. Combining short-form video content with brainrot content where the voices and context are nowhere near the normal form of communication can heavily affect and influence a young child's ability to communicate and speak. Research on Generation Alpha's language development in the digital age indicates that linguistic patterns are increasingly shaped by digital interactions, with both enhancing and potentially diminishing effects on vocabulary and communication. This dual potential makes the brainrot phenomenon a critical area to understand contemporary child language development [11].

Potential Limitations

1. Conceptual definition challenges: What content should be categorized as brainrot may be controversial which affects the clarity of research findings [9].
2. Causal limitations of cross-section design: instead of brainrot content causing weaker communication abilities, reverse causality is possible.
3. Self-report data bias: children's and parents' self-reports of brainrot content consumption can be influenced by social desirability bias.
4. Sample representativeness limitations: Brainrot content manifestations and family involvement norms may differ across culture contexts [4].

Expected Outcome

It is anticipated that children who consume brain-rot content at a high frequency will have difficulty communicating with adults and their peers who are not familiar with brain-rot content. However, it is also anticipated that the same children will be able to communicate amongst themselves where words and phrases derived or copied from brain-rot content serve as a new language.

Conclusion

As children learn communication and social cues in their childhood, by conducting this research, the effects of short-form content on children's abilities to communicate with adults and their peers can be investigated. As communication and social cues are important factors that children will need through their adulthood, it is crucial that these skills are developed properly in their early years and that there are no external factors negatively affecting the children's abilities to learn these skills.

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